

In the Footsteps of the Tzaddikim

A Companion for Our Journey Through Yiddishe Ungarn

A travel companion for our trip to the heilige kevarim of Ungarn — to the chassidishe and rabbinishe giants who lit up these little towns, and whose tziyonim still draw Yidden from every corner of the world.

About this companion

This little book travels along with us to the resting places of the great tzaddikim of north-eastern Ungarn. At every tziyon we stop at, you'll find:

- **Who he was** — where he came from, his rebbeim, his family, and how he came to lead his kehillah.
- **What he was known for** — his avodah, his brachos, his Torah, the maaisos Yidden still tell over today.
- **His sefarim** — the works he left behind for us.
- **The stories** — told the way they've been handed down, b'arichus, not chopped into a line or two.
- **At his tziyon today** — the yahrzeit, the minhagim, and what's good to know before you go.

A word before we begin: everything here is faithful to what has been handed down. Where something is a beloved tradition rather than a hard fact, we tell it as a tradition — but nothing is made up.

Our route

#	Site	Tzaddik
1	Nagykálló (Kálló)	R' Yitzchok Isaac Taub — the Kalover Rebbe
2	Bodrogkeresztúr (Kerestir)	R' Yeshaya Steiner — R' Shayeles Kerestirer
3	Újfehértó (Ratzfert)	R' Naftali Hertzka & R' Shalom Eliezer Halberstam
4	Csenger	R' Asher Anshel Yungreis — Menuchas Asher
5	Miskolc (Mishkoltz)	R' Chaim Mordechai Yaakov Gottlieb (Yagel Yaakov); R' Asher Anshel Wiener; R' Meyer Rosenfeld
6	Mád	R' Avraham Yehuda Schwartz (Kol Aryeh); R' Naftali Schwartz (Beis Naftali); R' Mordechai Leib Winkler (Levushei Mordechai)
7	Budapest (Pest)	R' Shimon ben David Oppenheim — Raavad of Pest (visited on the way back to the airport)

(Sites 1–4 and 6 sit in the Tokaj–Szabolcs northeast, the corridor from Kerestir eastward to Csenger; Miskolc lies just west of Kerestir. Budapest is the gateway city, visited on the return leg to the airport rather than on the eastern route.)

A bisel history: the Yidden of Ungarn

Before we set out, it's worth knowing a little of the world these tzaddikim lived in — how Yidden came to Ungarn in the first place, how the light of Chassidus reached its north-east, and what was so bitterly torn away in the churban. It is a long story, and a moving one.

How Yidden came to Ungarn

Yidden have lived on Hungarian soil for a very long time — there are traces of a Jewish presence already in Roman days. The first clear mention comes around the year 960, and by the Middle Ages there were settled kehillos: in 1251 King Béla IV gave the Yidden a charter of protection, and Jewish life held on through the centuries in spite of more than one bitter gezeira — among them an expulsion in 1360, after which the Yidden were eventually called back.

When the Turk ruled Buda (Ofen) from 1541, the kehillah there actually flourished. That came to a violent end in 1686, when the Christian armies retook the city and the Yidden of Buda were destroyed in the fighting, with harsh decrees following after.

Two worlds — and the Chasam Sofer

The Ungarn we picture was really rebuilt across the 1700s and 1800s, as Yidden streamed in from two directions: from Moravia and Bohemia in the west, and from Galicia in the north-east. Out of this grew two very different worlds.

In the **Oberland**, the north-west, Yidden spoke a German-flavored Yiddish and were fiercely, proudly frum — but they were not chassidim. Their address was Pressburg (Pozsony), and their towering leader was the **Chasam Sofer**, Reb Moshe Sofer (1762-1839). From 1806 until his very last day he led Pressburg and its yeshiva, which grew to some five hundred bochurim and became the most influential yeshiva in all of Central Europe. It was the Chasam Sofer who raised the banner that held back the Reformers — “chodosh assur min haTorah,” the new is forbidden by the Torah — and shaped the strong, uncompromising Yiddishkeit for which Ungarishe Yidden became known the world over.

In the **Unterland**, the north-east, hard by Galicia — that is where Chassidus would take root.

The light of Chassidus comes to Ungarn

It came early, and it came with song. Already in the 1780s, the **Kalover Rebbe**, Reb Yitzchok Eizik Taub of Nagykálló (c.1751-1821), had become the **first chassidishe rebbe on Hungarian soil** — the very first stop on our journey. In those same years the **Yismach Moshe**, Reb Moshe Teitelbaum of Ujhely (1759-1841), a talmid of the Chozeh of Lublin, planted Chassidus in the region and became the zeide of the Sighet and Satmar dynasties.

From there the wellsprings of Galicia — above all **Sanz** (the Divrei Chaim, Reb Chaim Halberstam, 1793-1876), together with **Belz** and **Ropshitz** — poured into the Unterland, and a whole world of heilige courts grew up: **Liska** (the Ach Pri Tevuah), **Kerestir** (Reb Shayeale, whom we will visit), **Munkács** (the Minchas Elazar), **Spinka** (the Imrei Yosef), and more. These little towns, so many of them on our very route, became names known wherever chassidim daven.

Golden years

Once the gezeiros eased and Yidden were at last granted civil rights — the great step came in 1867 — Hungarian Jewry blossomed as never before. By 1910 there were well over **900,000 Yidden** in greater Hungary, and Budapest had become one of the largest and most vibrant Jewish cities in the world, its Yidden to be found in every walk of life.

But the years after the First World War turned dark. Amid revolution and upheaval, a wave of antisemitic violence — the so-called White Terror of 1919-1921 — fell heavily on Yidden: a bitter taste of what was still to come.

The gezeiros

Ungarn carries the bitter distinction of passing what is widely called the **first anti-Jewish law in post-war Europe** — the numerus clausus of 1920, which slammed the university doors on Jewish young people. Then came the so-called Jewish Laws of 1938, 1939 and 1941, each one drawing the noose tighter: squeezing Yidden out of their parnassah, defining who was a Jew by race, and forbidding marriage between a Yid and a gentile. From 1939, Jewish men were torn from their families into brutal forced-labor battalions, where tens of thousands perished even before the worst began.

The bitter churban

The first great bloodletting came already in 1941, when Yidden who could not prove their citizenship were driven eastward and roughly **23,600 were murdered** at Kamenets-Podolsk.

The full churban came late, and with terrible speed. On **19 March 1944** the Germans marched into Ungarn, and with them came Eichmann, yemach shemo. Within weeks the Yidden of the countryside were herded into ghettos — and then, **between mid-May and early July 1944, in barely eight weeks, some 437,000 Yidden were torn from their towns and sent to Auschwitz**, where the great majority were killed the moment they stepped off the trains. The kehillos of the north-east — the very towns whose tzaddikim we travel to honor — were emptied and destroyed.

Budapest's Yidden were spared a little longer. But after the Arrow Cross seized power in October 1944, a fresh terror fell on the capital: a sealed ghetto, and thousands of Yidden shot on the banks of the Danube through that bitter winter. There were also shining acts of rescue — Raoul Wallenberg with his Swedish papers and safe houses, Carl Lutz of Switzerland, the Kasztner transport — and many were saved. The Russian army finally freed the city in the winter of 1945, with over 100,000 Yidden still alive there.

When it was over, of the roughly 825,000 Yidden who had been under Hungarian rule, **between 550,000 and 565,000 had been killed** — Hashem yikom damam. An entire world — the world of the tzaddikim in this book — was gone.

After the churban — and the Yidden who return

What survived was mostly in Budapest; the small-town kehillos of the countryside were all but wiped out, their shuls left silent. Nor did the survivors find peace: there were still ugly pogroms in 1946, and then the Communists, who choked Yiddishkeit, outlawed Zionist activity, and forced the kehillos under the heel of the state. Many who could, left — above all after the failed uprising of 1956.

And yet. Budapest remains to this day the largest Jewish kehillah in the whole region — most of Hungary's Yidden live there still, around the great Dohány shul, the largest in Europe. And in recent decades something beautiful has happened: Yidden

have begun streaming back to Ungarn — not to settle, but to daven at the heilige kevarim. Tens of thousands come to Kerestir for Reb Shayele's yahrzeit on Gimmel Iyar; they come to Kálló, to Ujhely, to Liska. That return — that pull of Yidden back to their tzaddikim — is exactly the journey this little book sets out to make.

1. Nagykálló (Kálló) — the Kalover Rebbe

Reb Yitzchok Eizik Taub — der heiliger Kalover, the Sweet Singer of Israel (c. 1751-1821)

Who he was. Reb Yitzchok Eizik Taub — known with love simply as Reb Eizik'l Kaliver — was the Rav of Nagykálló (in Yiddish, Kalov or Kaliv), the zeide of the Kaliv dynasty, and the **first chassidishe rebbe to take root on Hungarian soil**. He came into the world around 1751. The masorah tells that his family carried **Sephardic roots**, and to this day a few old matzeivos near his ohel are said to remember that lineage.

His beginnings were anything but grand. The way it is lovingly told: little Itzik was barely ten years old when his father was niftar, and the boy had to leave the cheder to help his widowed mother, Reizel, keep bread on the table. He hired himself out to a landowner and spent his days alone in the fields and woods outside the town, **minding the geese**. To pass the lonely hours he did as the Hungarian shepherd-boys did — he played a little flute and sang their wistful village melodies.

One Motzaei Shabbos the wandering tzaddik **Reb Leib Sarah's** — a talmid of the Baal Shem Tov, who roamed Europe in disguise redeeming Yidden from captivity — felt himself drawn, he knew not why, into Hungary. In a field outside Kalov he came upon the orphan boy with his geese and his flute, and in one glance he saw what no one else had seen: that here was a neshama gevoha, a lofty soul "from the upper World of Song." He went straight to the widow Reizel, promised her a monthly stipend to make up for the lost help, and asked to take her son away to learn. When he brought the boy to his rebbe he said, so the story goes, "I have brought you a special neshama from the Chamber of Song."

Reb Leib brought him to **Nikolsburg**, to the great **Rebbe Reb Shmelke**, and through him the boy was drawn fully into the world of Chassidus; he became as well a close talmid of the **Rebbe Reb Elimelech of Lizensk**, the Noam Elimelech. Around 1781 he came home, was made Rav of Nagykálló, and there he sat for some **forty years**, drawing thousands of Yidden close to the Aibershter — the first chassidishe court in all of Ungarn.

What he was known for. The Kalover's whole avodah was **song**. He is remembered above every other title as the Sweet Singer of Israel, the rebbe who served Hashem with niggun, with simcha, and with an aching longing for the Geulah. And he gave over a teaching that is the key to everything he did: the melodies one hears in the

world, he said, are really **holy niggunim from the Beis HaMikdash** that fell, over the long galus, “lost among the nations.” When a Yid hears such a tune and lifts it back to kedusha, he is **redeeming a fallen spark** and carrying it home. So when Reb Eizik’l heard a Hungarian shepherd’s song, he did not hear a peasant’s tune — he heard a captive spark of the song of the Beis HaMikdash, waiting to be brought back.

The stories.

“Szól a kakas már” — the rooster is already crowing. This is his most famous niggun, and the one Yidden still sing. The Rebbe, who had himself been a shepherd, would walk out among the Hungarian herders and learn their songs; from one of them he heard a haunting tune and, as the tradition puts it, **“bought” the song from him.** And here is the wonder told from rebbe to rebbe: the very moment Reb Eizik’l acquired the melody, **the gentile shepherd forgot it completely** — it vanished from his mouth as though it had never been his. That, said the Rebbe, was the proof: the song had never truly belonged to the shepherd at all. It was a holy niggun of the Beis HaMikdash, only held in pledge among the nations until its rightful owner came to redeem it — and once a Yid carried it home, the nation could hold it no more. The words themselves are the secret of the whole song: they begin as a simple Hungarian shepherd’s poem — a rooster crowing as dawn breaks, a beautiful bird waiting in a green forest — and then, all at once, they turn into the holy tongue and reveal what they were really about all along: “Yiboneh haMikdash, ir Tziyon temaleh” — the Beis HaMikdash will be rebuilt and the city of Tziyon refilled. The crowing rooster is the first light of the Geulah; the bird that must “always wait” is Klal Yisroel, faithful through the long night of galus, certain it will yet come home.

“Erdő, erdő” — forest, O forest. In the same way he took another Hungarian shepherd’s love-song and revealed its true face. Where the village sang “Forest, O forest, how vast you are; rose, O rose, how far you are... who will lead me out of the forest to my rose?” — the Rebbe sang: “Galus, O galus, how vast you are; Shechina, Shechina, how far you are... who will lead me out of the galus and bring me back to the Shechina?” The endless forest is the bitter exile; the faraway rose is the Shechina from which we are torn — and the whole song is one cry to be brought home.

Hallel at the tish of Reb Elimelech. They tell that once, as the Rebbe Reb Elimelech of Lizhensk began to say Torah at the tish, the young Kaliver suddenly sprang up and ran through the whole house singing Hallel at the top of his voice, to everyone’s astonishment. Afterward he explained: when the heilige rebbe said over the Torah, he was so flooded with hislahavus that he felt as though he were standing in the Beis HaMikdash itself, bringing the Korban Pesach — and how could a Yid stand in the Mikdash on Pesach and not sing Hallel?

His sefarim. Like many of the early chassidishe rebbes, the Kalover left his mark not in a printed sefer but in his **niggunim** and his spoken Torah, carried down by his chassidim — above all Szól a kakas már and Erdő, erdő, which Yidden sing to this day. (A handful of his written letters survive in collectors’ hands.)

His family and the Kaliv dynasty. From Reb Eizik'l grew the **Kaliv dynasty**, carried on by his sons and their sons down the generations. In our own time the name was borne by the famed **Kaliver Rebbe, Reb Menachem Mendel Taub (1923-2019)** — a survivor of the churban who rebuilt the chassidus in Eretz Yisroel, gave his life to keeping the memory of the kedoshim alive, and made Szól a kakas már beloved to a whole new generation.

At his tziyon today. Reb Eizik'l is buried in the old beis hachaim of **Nagykálló**, beneath an **ohel**, ringed by those old stones said to recall his Sephardic roots. It is one of the great kever-stops of Ungarn — Yidden come to light candles, to daven and to leave kvitlach, and the place is wrapped in stories of childless couples who came and were bentched with children. The great day is his yahrzeit on **7 Adar** — which is also the yahrzeit of Moshe Rabbeinu — when chassidim and travelers pour in by the busload from England, Eretz Yisroel and America. So strong was the pull that even in the dark years under the Communists, Yidden never stopped coming to daven at the kever of the first rebbe of Ungarn.

2. Bodrogkeresztúr (Kerestir) — Reb Shayele

Reb Yeshaya (Shayele) Steiner — der heiliger Kerestirer (1851-1925)

Who he was. Ask any Yid who Reb Shayele was, and the answer comes in one breath: the baal hachnasas orchim of all baalei hachnasas orchim. He was born in 1851 in Zboró (Zborov), into a poor but deeply ehrliche home. When little Shaya'le was only three years old his father, Reb Moshe, was niftar, and his widowed mother, Hentsha Miriam, raised him in real poverty — which is why, his whole life, Yidden called him with such tenderness simply Reb Shaya'le ben Reb Moshe.

When he was about twelve his mother sent him off to learn, to the court of the heilige **Reb Tzvi Hersh of Liska**, the Ach Pri Tevuah — himself a great Hungarian tzaddik and baal mofes. The boy attached himself with all his heart, and the Liska Rebbe came to love him so that he made him his **meshamesh**, his personal attendant. One of his jobs was to hand out bread to the crowds of poor people who streamed to Liska — and it was there, serving the poor in his own poverty, that everything Reb Shaya'le would become was already planted.

After Liska he drew close to the **Divrei Chaim of Sanz**, and after Sanz he became one of the eltere, the senior chassidim, of **Reb Mordechai of Nadvorna**. It was Reb Mordechai who told him to settle in the little village of **Bodrogkeresztúr (Kerestir)**, near Miskolc, where he would live out his life. Reb Shaya'le never pushed himself forward as a rebbe — it was Reb Mordechai who, in effect, made him one: when Yidden came to Nadvorna from that region, the Rebbe would send them back to Reb Shaya'le, telling them plainly that they belonged to him. From there his name

as a baal yeshuos spread, until tens of thousands of chassidim were streaming to tiny Kerestir.

What he was known for. Feeding hungry Yidden was not a sideline of Reb Shaya'le's avodah — it was his avodah. They tell that his house had no locks on the doors; it stood open day and night to any traveler, beggar or wanderer. If he found a stranger asleep under his roof in the morning, he would make him breakfast with his own hands. He and the Rebbetzin Sarah fed thousands; he gave away his own bread and his own food, and when there was not a penny left in his pocket he borrowed in order to keep giving. It is told that he once sold his own Shabbos clothing to make a wedding for a poor orphan girl. Even on Rosh Hashanah, between the long tefillos, he could be found cutting slices of cake to be sure the guests had eaten. A gentile mail-carrier who spoke at his levaya said it plainly: "I handled his mail myself, and I know he personally supported hundreds of poor families across Hungary." His chassidim loved to point out that his name, ישעיה, has the same gematria as פרנסה — a fitting hint for a tzaddik whose whole life was Klal Yisroel's sustenance.

The stories.

The bottomless sack of bilkelach. Already as the young meshamesh in Liska, his task was to hand out rolls to the poor. The sack would visibly empty — and still his hand kept coming out full, roll after roll, until every last person had been fed. The heilige Liska watched and said the words that became famous: "Look at my Shaya'le giving out the bread — the sack is empty, and he keeps on giving..." That bracha of bread-that-never-runs-out followed him all his days; Yidden saw the same wonder at his own table in Kerestir.

The fish for Shabbos. One Erev Shabbos there was no fish to be had in Kerestir — the river had come up empty and the town faced a Shabbos with no fish. A worried Yid came to the Rebbe, and Reb Shaya'le told him simply not to worry, there would be fish. And so it was: the next morning the nets came up full. (In the warmer telling, a fine kosher fish was brought straight to the Rebbe's own door by a bird, so that the town would have its Shabbos fish.)

The borscht and the soldiers. A crowd of hungry soldiers once arrived, far more than the food on hand could feed. Reb Shaya'le took his spoon, stirred the last of the pot, and kept ladling out borscht and potatoes until every last man was satisfied — the food simply did not run out.

The picture that keeps away mice. This is the best-known thing about Reb Shaya'le in the wider world — that hanging his picture in the house keeps away mice. The maaiseh told behind it: a chossid who owned a grain warehouse came to the Rebbe because mice were devouring his livelihood. Reb Shaya'le first asked him whether the local pastor was kind to Yidden or harsh with them; when the man answered that the pastor was harsh, the Rebbe told him to go to the warehouse and announce, in the Rebbe's name, that the mice should go to the pastor's estate. The man did exactly that — and the mice poured out and streamed off toward the pastor's land, and his business was saved. From then, Yidden plagued by mice began hanging Reb

Shaya'le's picture. A word of honesty, the way it deserves to be told: this is a beloved folk-segula, not a halacha and not a documented instruction of the Rebbe — and indeed some of Reb Shaya'le's own descendants say the warehouse story never happened and that the Rebbe did not even want his picture taken. Tell it warmly for what it is, and tell it true.

His brachos and yeshuos. In his lifetime Reb Shaya'le was among the most sought-after baalei yeshuos in all of Hungary — for parnassah above all, and for refuah, children, and protection from those who wished Yidden harm. One honest, sober story survives from a local family: a woman sick with pneumonia received a remedy from the Rebbe each day for eight days; on the ninth day he said, "Today I give you nothing — it would be of no use," and that day she was niftar. They understood that the tzaddik saw what had already been decreed Above, and would not promise what was not to be.

His humility and his tisch. Everything about him was koton — small, humble. He called himself only "Shaya'le," and he saw in every single Yid, whatever his station, a beautiful, pure neshama. His tefillah was like fire, and he seemed to live somewhere between heaven and earth — yet he would break off from that very avodah the moment a Yid needed a cold drink or a warm bed. His Motzaei Shabbos Melaveh Malka was famous, a great feast in his courtyard before huge crowds — a custom recreated in Kerestir to this very day.

His sefarim and his family. Reb Shaya'le left no great sefer and founded no reigning dynasty — and that is itself part of his greatness: purely through chesed and yeshuos he became one of the most beloved tzaddikim of all. His partner in everything was the Rebbetzin Sarah. His only son, **Reb Avraham Steiner**, succeeded him but led for barely two years before he too was niftar, in 1927. The kehillah of Kerestir was destroyed in the churban of 1944, and members of the Rebbe's family were among the kedoshim.

At his tziyon today. Reb Shaya'le was niftar on **Gimmel (3) Iyar 5685 (1925)**. On his deathbed — wholly in character — he told his family: "There will be a great funeral, and many will come from the surrounding towns. Prepare large pots of food, so that the people who come should not go hungry." And he promised his grandchildren: "As long as you continue the chesed for Klal Yisroel, I will bring about yeshuos." His kever in Bodrogkeresztúr draws Yidden all year round, but on the **yahrzeit, Gimmel Iyar**, the sleepy village is transformed — tens of thousands come, the guest shuls run around the clock, mountains of kvittlach are left at the tziyon, and — exactly as the Rebbe lived — everyone is fed, for free. "Reb Shaye's Kitchen" feeds visitors and local families all year, carrying on the hachnasas orchim that was his whole life.

3. Újfehértó (Ratzfert) — Reb Hertzkeleh and the Sanzer-Ratzferter

Ratzfert, in Szabolcs county, is a “double” stop. It is the resting place of the town’s own wonder-working Rav, **Reb Hertzkeleh**, whose ohel is the reason chassidim make the trip — and it was the seat of **Reb Shalom Eliezer Halberstam**, the youngest son of the Divrei Chaim of Sanz. The cemetery is still cared for by Reb Hertzkeleh’s descendants, and there is a mikveh nearby for those who come.

A) Reb Naftali Hertzka Halevi Zilberman — Reb Hertzkeleh Ratzferter (1820-1897)

Who he was. Born in **Máriapócs** in 1820, a Levi, the son of Reb Yaakov Peretz and his wife Frumet. He learned by a number of great rabbanim and then drew into the chassidishe world, attaching himself above all to the **Divrei Chaim of Sanz**, and afterward to the Divrei Chaim’s son, **Reb Yechezkel Shraga of Shinova**. He served first as Rav of Kántorjánosi, and then, from about 1880 until his petira in 1897, as Rav and Admor of **Ratzfert** — and it is those last seventeen-odd years that made the town’s name.

What he was known for. Reb Hertzkeleh was famed across his region as a **baal mofes**, a tzaddik to whose door chassidim — and, the masorah tells, gentiles too — streamed for a bracha and a yeshuah. His holy sayings and stories were gathered by his grandson into the sefer **Zichron Naftali**, which is where his maaisos are faithfully preserved.

His family. His son, **Reb Yaakov Peretz Zilberman** — named, in the lovely way, for Reb Hertzkeleh’s own father — was himself a tzaddik who served in Hodász. The family carries on, and its descendants are the ones who to this day keep up the Ratzfert beis hachaim and built the mikveh for visitors.

At his tziyon today. Reb Hertzkeleh was niftar in 1897, his yahrzeit on **9 Tishrei**, erev Yom Kippur, and he lies in the **Ratzfert cemetery**, where his ohel is the heart of the visit — a pilgrimage point for Sanzer chassidim and for all who are drawn to the world of Chassidus.

B) Reb Shalom Eliezer Halberstam — the Sanzer-Ratzferter, Hy”d (1862-1944)

Who he was. The youngest son of the **Divrei Chaim of Sanz** — the last living link to his father’s court. The Divrei Chaim named him Shalom Eliezer after two tzaddikim he revered, the Sar Shalom of Belz and Reb Eliezer of Dzikov. He was still a boy of about fourteen when his father was niftar in 1876, and he was raised by his mother and his older brothers, themselves great Sanzer rebbes. In time he made his way — from Russia, to Galicia, and around the turn of the century into Hungary — and established his court in **Ratzfert**, where he led his kehillah for some forty years.

What he was known for. A **baal mofes** to whom thousands streamed for brachos, who held his flock with a strong hand in the ways of his holy forebears, the talmidim of the Baal Shem Tov. Such was the honor he commanded that even government officials would come to his children's weddings. Among his sons-in-law was a tzaddik whose name says everything about the family's stature — **Reb Ben Zion Halberstam, the Bobover Rav, the Kedushas Tzion, Hy"d.**

His last years, Hy"d. In 1939, sensing with ruach hakodesh the churban that was coming, he tried to reach Yerushalayim, saying: "I know a great destruction is coming upon the world, and I know that in Eretz Yisroel one is able to bring about yeshuos." He could not complete the journey, and he labored in vain to rescue his son-in-law the Bobover. He was driven into the Nyíregyháza ghetto — where his rebbetzin was niftar in the days before Shavuot — and then to **Auschwitz-Birkenau**, where he was murdered, on **16 Sivan 5704 (1944).**

One account must be told in full at his memory. A young man, **Yehoshua Rosenbloom**, forced to work in the Sonderkommando at Birkenau, came upon the aged Ratzferter Rav. Realizing whom he was looking at, the boy helped the tzaddik put on his tallis katan so that he could say Viduy before his death. Afterward the Rebbe took his hand warmly and said: "You, my child, will be saved and will live. But I beg of you with all my strength — remember well what you have seen, and tell the whole world what the resha'im did to us. Tell it!" Rosenbloom survived, and carried the Rebbe's last words out of that place.

A note for the visitor. Reb Shalom Eliezer has **no kever to visit** — he was murdered and his body burned in Birkenau. Yidden honor his memory in Ratzfert, the seat of his court, and at Auschwitz; but there is no ohel for him here. The Ratzfert kever that pilgrims daven at is that of **Reb Hertzkeleh** above.

4. Csenger — the Menuchas Asher

Reb Asher Anshel Yungreis — the Menuchas Asher (1806-1873)

Who he was. Rav of Csenger for some forty years, a posek among the gedolim of Hungarian Yiddishkeit, and the zeide of the **Yungreis** rabbinic dynasty of the town. He was born in 1806; his father was **Reb Shmuel Halevi Yungreis**, author of *Toras Edus* on Shas Mishnayos, and his mother **Miriam Yittel** was a daughter of **Reb Asher Anshel Wiener, the first Rav of Miskolc** — after whom this Reb Asher Anshel was named, and whom we will meet again at the Avas Hill. The family told of a chain of some forty generations of rabbanim. As a bochur he was the outstanding talmid of **Reb Yaakov Kopel of Altenkustadt** — "**Kopel Charif**," Kopel the Sharp — in whose yeshiva he learned nine years running, already then fasting every week from Motzaei Shabbos until Tuesday night.

What he was known for. Three things. First, he was a **baal mofes and a healer** — "thousands and tens of thousands came to receive a bracha from his mouth and were

saved,” above all in matters of refuah, until the gedolim of the dor called him Mofes HaDor, the wonder of the generation. Second, his **tzidkus**: it was said he fasted away a third of his life, and undertook three-day fasts in times of communal trouble. And third, his **tzedakah**: after his petira, receipts were found documenting fortunes given away — supporting widows, marrying off orphans, sending great sums to Eretz Yisroel.

The story of the malach Refael. This is the maaiseh to tell at his kever. It was said of the Menuchas Asher that the **malach Refael appeared to him and gave him a sefer of refuos**, a book of cures, and that from it he would prescribe remedies for the sick who streamed to him. The proof came from an unlikely witness: the owner of the local pharmacy — a convert, a former Yid — revealed that many of the medicines the Rav prescribed were not even to be had in his pharmacy, and yet the patients recovered. From this all understood that the cures came not from any medicine at all, but from the tefillos and the zechus of the tzaddik.

His sefer and his family. His enduring name comes from his sefer, **Menuchas Asher**; his yeshiva, though small, was reckoned an important one and sent out many rabbanim. His son **Reb Avraham** succeeded him in Csenger, and the rabbanus stayed in Yungreis hands right down to a later **Reb Asher Anshel Yungreis (1875-1944, Hy”d)**, who led Csenger for some forty years and was murdered with his kehillah in the churban. From this wider Yungreis family, in our own generation, came **Rebbetzin Esther Jungreis**, the founder of Hineni and a survivor of Bergen-Belsen — a branch of the same Hungarian rabbinishe family living on.

At his tziyon today. The Menuchas Asher was niftar on **5 Kislev 1873** and lies in the **Csenger beis hachaim**. His kever became, in the words of those who describe it, an even sho’eves — a magnet — where Yidden come to daven for yeshuos, and above all for **refuos**, just as he was known for in life. The fitting way to come is with a kvittel and a tefillah for a choleh, calling on the zechus of the tzaddik who received the sefer refuos from the malach Refael.

5. Miskolc (Mishkoltz) — the tzaddikim of the Avas Hill

Miskolc was one of the great Orthodox kehillas of Ungarn, and high over the town, on the old **Avas Hill beis hachaim**, lie the rabbanim around whom this stop is built — among them an early founding Rav, a long-serving Chief Rav of the Orthodox kehillah, and a chassidishe tzaddik who held court here in the town’s last frum generation.

A) Reb Chaim Mordechai Yaakov Gottlieb — the Yagel Yaakov (1876-1936)

Who he was. A son of Reb Avraham Gottlieb, his very name was a crown of three tzaddikim: **Chaim** for the Divrei Chaim of Sanz, **Mordechai** for his uncle Reb Mor-

dechai the dayan of Rimanov, and **Yaakov** for his zeide, Reb Yankele of Boyan. So he was Sanz-rooted by name and by family — though his own derech grew up in the Hungarian chassidishe world of Chust and Sighet, close to the Imrei Yosef of Spinka and to the Arugas HaBosem, and he had semichah from the Maharsham. He served as Rav first in Borşa, then for some fourteen years in Oberwischau (Vişeu de Sus), and in Rozavlea, before being called in 1926 to be **Av Beis Din of the chassidishe kehillah of Miskolc** — its “Kehillas HaSefaradim,” the Nusach Sefard community — where he founded a yeshiva and led until his petira ten years later.

What he was known for. Though he held the seat of a town Rav, he conducted himself in the way of a rebbe — a tish on Motzaei Shabbos and at shalosh seudos, and chassidim who brought him their kvittlach — and he was counted among the leading rabbanim of pre-churban Hungary and reputed a baal mofes.

His sefer. His teachings fill the many volumes of **Yagel Yaakov** — on the Torah, drashos, chiddushim on Shas, and responsa across all four chelkei Shulchan Aruch.

A story to tell. This one is about the Rebbe as a teacher, and it surfaced years after his petira. His son, **Reb Yehuda Gottlieb**, found himself after the war in the Feldafing DP camp together with the Klausenberger Rebbe. On the first night of Sukkos, the man who ran the camp kitchen came in a panic: a piece of meat that had not been properly prepared — the gid hanasheh not removed — had fallen into the great pot of food cooked for the whole camp. The Klausenberger Rebbe, who had no seforim there to pasken from, sent the question to Reb Yehuda. Reb Yehuda walked into the kitchen and ruled the food permitted, citing the Rema in Yoreh De’ah, siman 91 — and when the Klausenberger marveled that he had paskened with no sefer before him, Reb Yehuda explained: years earlier, learning these very halachos with his father the Yagel Yaakov, his father had told him to commit the Rema’s words to heart, saying, “You may yet meet such a question one day” — and had described to him precisely this case, meat with the gid falling into a pot cooked for many. The she’eilah in the camp had come exactly as his father had foreseen.

At his tziyon. He was niftar on **8 Tammuz 5696 (1936)** and is buried on the Avas Hill in Miskolc.

B) Reb Asher Anshel Wiener — the first Rav of Miskolc (d. 1800)

The founding-era Rav of Miskolc and its county, serving from about 1774 until his petira in 1800. He came of the distinguished **Wiener family of Prague**, and the tradition tells that his own rebbe was the famed Reb Yonasan Eybeschütz; he was succeeded by his son, Reb Avraham. There is a sweet thread here that ties our journey together: Reb Asher Anshel Wiener was the maternal zeide of the **Menuchas Asher of Csenger**, who was named after him. His matzeiva is among the venerated stones of the Avas Hill.

C) Reb Meyer (Mór) Rosenfeld — Chief Orthodox Rav of Miskolc (1830-1908)

Reb Meyer came to Miskolc from the rabbanus of Nádudvar and was elected **Chief Rav of the Orthodox kehillah in 1879**, serving with great honor for some thirty years. He is remembered as a steady, respected leader who knew how to keep the peace among the factions of his day, and he left a rabbinishe family of sons and sons-in-law who took up the rabbanus after him. He rests in an ohel on the Avas Hill.

6. Mád — the Kol Aryeh, the Beis Naftali and the Levushei Mordechai

Mád sits in the Tokaj-Hegyalja wine country, and it was a serious Oberland rabbinic seat. Two things anchor a visit: the old walled **beis hachaim**, with stones two and three hundred years old, and the beautiful baroque **Kol Aryeh shul**, built in 1795, lovingly restored between 2000 and 2004 and awarded a Europa Nostra diploma. Three gedolim draw Yidden to the town.

A) Reb Avraham Yehuda HaKohen Schwartz — the Kol Aryeh (1824-1883)

Who he was. Born in Mád on Rosh Chodesh Av 5584 (1824), a son of Reb Pinchas Zelig. As a boy of thirteen he entered the **Pressburg yeshiva** and became one of the youngest talmidim of the **Chasam Sofer**; he later had semichah from Reb Binyamin Wolf Löw. But the turn that shaped his life came from Sanz. Though he was raised in the Pressburg world, which kept its distance from Chassidus, he once heard the **Divrei Chaim of Sanz** say over a deep derosha — building up difficulties in the Rambam and resolving them all to the one truth, that there is but one G-d in heaven and earth — and the young Mádier was so overcome that he bound himself to Sanz for the rest of his days. The masorah treasures that he went to Sanz for Shavuot some twenty-six years in a row.

What he was known for. He was reckoned among the leading rabbanim of nineteenth-century Hungary, a gaon of fabled memory — it was said he knew most of the Tosafos across Shas by heart. He opened a yeshiva in Mád while still a young man, and he stood in the great communal battles of his day, taking part in the rabbinical assembly at Michalovce in 1866 and the Budapest Congress of 1869. He served as Rav of Beregszász from 1861, and around 1881 returned home to Mád as its Rav until his petira.

His sefer. He wrote essentially one work — the responsa **Kol Aryeh**, “the Voice of the Lion” — but its weight among Hungarian poskim was anything but small, and it is for this sefer that the restored Mád shul is named.

At his tziyon. He was niftar on **24 Tishrei 5644 (1883)** and is buried in Mád.

B) Reb Naftali Schwartz — the Beis Naftali (1843-1896)

The son of the Kol Aryeh, who **succeeded his father as Rav of Mád** in 1883 and carried his seat and his Torah for some thirteen years. He left the sefer **Beis Naftali**, and he is buried in Mád, near his father.

C) Reb Mordechai Leib Winkler — the Levushei Mordechai (1844/45-1932)

Who he was. Born around 1844 near Nitra into a poor home that poured everything into his learning — the tradition tells that by twelve he had whole sections of Shas by heart and was saying over his own chiddushim. He learned by three of the Chasam Sofer's talmidim, chief among them his primary rebbe, **Reb Yisrael Yitzchak Aharon Landesberg of Grosswardein (Oradea)**, whose foremost talmid he became. He was Rav of Mezótelegd from 1872 and of Brezovica from 1880, and around 1901 he came to **Mád as Rav and Rosh Yeshiva**, where he sat for some thirty-one years until his petira.

What he was known for. He was one of the foremost **poskim** of pre-war Hungary. His responsa, the **Levushei Mordechai**, run to fifteen hundred and more teshuvos sent to some hundred and seventy-four places — even a handful as far as America — a measure of how widely Yidden turned to him; it remains a sefer poskim reach for to this day, and he took up even the newest she'eilos of his time, such as the use of electricity on Shabbos.

At his tziyon. Reb Mordechai Leib was niftar on **17 Tammuz 5692 (1932)** — the very day, the seforim note with feeling, on which the Luchos were broken. He is buried in Mád, completing the trio of gedolim who draw Yidden to the town.

7. Budapest (Pest) — the Raavad of Pest

Visited on the way back to the airport.

Reb Shimon ben David Oppenheim — the Raavad of Pest (c. 1749/1753 - 1851)

Who he was. Reb Shimon ben David Oppenheim was born in **Boskovice (Boskowitz), Moravia**, a son of Reb David of Kromau, and learned by **Reb Binyamin Wolf of Boskowitz**. He taught Torah in Prague, then in Freistadt from about 1793, and in **1801 he was appointed a dayan in Pest** — a post he would hold for roughly **half a century**, as the **Raavad**, the head of the beis din, of the great rising kehillah of Pest. The Oppenheim name came to him through his marriage into the Oppenheim family of Freistadt (his rebbetzin, Slava, was a daughter of Reb Yehuda Leib Oppenheim). One word of care for the traveler: he is not the famous Reb David Oppenheim of Prague, the great bibliophile who lived a century earlier — they share only the name.

What he was known for. For some fifty years he was a leading dayan and posek of early Pest, and he was zoche to a remarkable old age — the masorah tells that he lived to **102**. He was also a substantial mechaber. His seforim include **Amud HaShachar** (Prague, 1789), brought out as a young man of about twenty-six; **Har HaKarmel** (Prague, 1812), on the halachos of niddah and mikvah; and **Nezer HaKodesh** (Buda, 1831), on middos and mussar.

The stories.

The son he outlived. His son, **Reb Avrohom Chaim Oppenheim**, served as Rav in Pécs but was niftar young, at about twenty-eight. The aged father gathered his son's writings and brought them to print himself — **Har Avel** (1824) and **Neshmas Chaim** (1829), the latter on the eternity of the neshama. There is something deeply moving in an old man in his seventies giving his lost son that kind of immortality, and in the title he chose to send out into the world: the soul lives on.

The tefillah on his matzeiva. It is told that the Raavad composed a tefillah and asked that it be engraved upon his own matzeiva, and to this day Yidden who come to his kever daven with the words inscribed on the stone.

The kever found whole. It is further told that when, in later years, his resting place had to be moved, his body and tachrichim were found whole — the classic sign of a tzaddik. This is related as masorah rather than documented fact, but it sits well with what is certain: that he was niftar in 1851, before either of today's Pest batei ha-chaim existed, so his grave was indeed moved at some point to its present place.

His sefarim. His teachings live in the works he wrote — Amud HaShachar, Har HaKarmel, and Nezer HaKodesh — and in the seforim of his son that he lovingly brought to print.

At his tziyon today. The Raavad is buried in **Budapest**, but because he was niftar in 1851 — before the Salgótarjáni utca cemetery (opened 1874) and the Kozma utca cemetery (opened 1891) — his kever was reinterred, and the sources differ on which of the two it now lies in. It is well worth confirming the exact plot with the Budapest chevra kadisha before you go. Coming as we do on the way back to the airport, it is a fitting last stop: the senior dayan who watched over Pest for half a century, in the city that remains, after everything, the great surviving kehillah of Ungarn.